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Léa

The stench of boiling cabbage reached the boardinghouse's upper rooms as Léa scanned the help-wanted ads in *La Feuille Libre*, Orléans' local paper. Madame Martin let the cabbage cook all day, adding water, salt, sometimes a rutabaga or turnip, and if the boarders were lucky, a sliver of *lardon*. Léa swore that after the war was over, she'd never eat cabbage again.

Most of the official notices were from the government, requesting volunteers to work in Germany or in war-related industries in Orléans, which promised good salaries and better housing. Léa glanced through them. They weren't for her. She would never allow herself to stoop so low to assist Germany in continuing the war.

Despite being turned away from the sugar refinery and vinegar factories, Léa hadn't lost hope. She'd weathered hard times before and refused to let these setbacks deter her. Determined to find a job, she considered applying for domestic service positions, cleaning or childcare, even if it meant working for the wealthy. A knot of tension formed in her back. These were the people profiting off the war. Still, she recalled Maître Mallon's advice: *be realistic . . . do what's best for you and Rose*. Léa had to compromise, balancing what was right with what she needed to survive, especially after her exchange with Madame Martin this morning.

The floorboards in the hallway creaked; every move echoed through the boardinghouse's old beams and rafters. It must be Rose returning from work. Léa couldn't delay sharing the news of her job loss with her sister any longer. She didn't want to trouble Rose but it was no longer something she could hide.

The door opened. Rose, beaming, entered.